

# PROJECT ISLAND PUBLICATION 2: CAREGIVER WELLBEING

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## STUDY BACKGROUND

- Caring for a child with a neurodevelopmental condition can have a major impact on family wellbeing. Research shows that caregivers often experience higher levels of stress, anxiety, and low mood, and that these challenges may be linked to their child's behaviour and communication profile.
- However, very little research has focused specifically on caregivers of minimally verbal (MV) children. MV children are a diverse group who use few or no spoken words, but differ widely in how they communicate and in their underlying diagnoses.
- For many families, difficulties understanding a child's wants and needs — regardless of whether communication happens through speech, gestures, symbols, or other methods — may be an important factor affecting caregiver wellbeing.

## METHOD

- **Participants:** We studied 193 MV children and their caregivers. The children were on average 7.6-years-old and most were boys (73%). Most caregivers who took part were mothers (91%).
- **Measures:**
  - **Caregiver wellbeing:** This was measured via two questionnaires: one assessing general positive wellbeing in everyday life, and one which focussed more specifically on caregiver wellbeing and satisfaction with family life.
  - **Child communication skills:** We combined caregiver reports with direct observations of how children communicated.
- We also took into account other factors that could affect caregiver wellbeing, including family demographics, children's daily living skills, autistic traits, and behavioural and health conditions such as ADHD and gastrointestinal difficulties.

## FINDINGS

- Caregivers of MV children reported significantly lower wellbeing than is typically seen in the general population.
- Children's communication skills were not linked to caregivers' general positive wellbeing. However, better child communication skills were related to higher caregiver-specific wellbeing and greater satisfaction with family life.
- Other child characteristics were also important. Higher levels of non-social autism traits were linked to lower caregiver wellbeing and family life satisfaction. In addition, children's ADHD-related behaviours and gastrointestinal difficulties were associated with poorer caregiver wellbeing across both measures.

## CONCLUSIONS

- Caregivers of MV children appear to be at particularly high risk of poor wellbeing. These findings highlight the need for targeted, family-centred interventions which provide better emotional and practical support for caregivers of MV children.
- MV children's communication skills are linked to caregiver-specific wellbeing and family life satisfaction.
  - When children struggle to communicate their wants and needs effectively – whether through speech or other forms of communication – this may increase parenting stress and make daily routines more difficult to manage.
  - Interventions which support children's communication skills may also have benefits for caregiver wellbeing and family functioning.
- Other child characteristics also played an important role.
  - ADHD-related behaviours, gastrointestinal difficulties, and non-social autism traits were all associated with poorer caregiver wellbeing.
  - For MV children, limited spoken language may make these challenges harder for caregivers to understand and manage.
  - These findings highlight the importance of holistic support that addresses both communication needs and co-occurring behavioural or health difficulties.

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